

Maryland Small Ruminant

Natural and Home Remedies for Sheep/Goats A-Z

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There are numerous natural and home remedies -- things on your kitchen shelf, in your medicine cabinet, or readily available at farm supply stores -- that are often used to prevent or treat disease conditions

or provide supportive therapy to sheep/goats.

While the benefits may be mostly anecdotal and research is often lacking, they are frequently used by producers -- and might help.



Activated charcoal

Activated charcoal is a powder comprised of wood, bamboo, coal, or coconut shells that have been burned at a very high temperature. Activated charcoal is a proven supplement that benefits the healthy gut of animals. It is used in animal feeds as an antidote for poisoning and to control diarrhea. Activated charcoal can be given to individual animals who have consumed toxins or to help control their diarrhea. Activated charcoal is available as a powder, gel, or supplement (for feed).

Aspirin

Aspirin (or ibuprofen) can be an option for those who don't have prescription pain

meds/anti-inflammatory drugs on-hand.

Aspirin is a non-steroidal anti-inflammatory drug used to treat pain, fever, and inflammation. It can be given to sheep/goats for these same reasons. Some producers opt for baby aspirin, especially for smaller animals. There are also aspirin formulations (boluses and powder) commercially available for livestock, though not all are approved for sheep/goats. While oral aspirin has not been found to be an effective pain reliever when administered immediately after application of rubber rings (for docking/castrating), its use may warrant further investigation.

Antacids

Over-the-counter antacids, such as Mylanta® and Tums®, can help to neutralize acid in the gut. They can be used to treat bloat, acidosis, and other digestive upsets in sheep/goats.

Apple Cider Vinegar

While all sorts of claims have been made about apple cider vinegar, few have been substantiated. Regardless, apple cider vinegar (raw, unfiltered) is a source of nutrients, including probiotics, that can be given to animals that are off-feed or require a nutritional boost. Some producers provide apple cider vinegar on a regular basis to their animals, touting the "potential" health benefits. Apple cider vinegar is commercially available in gallons and barrels. You can improve its palatability by mixing it with molasses.



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Baking Soda

Baking soda (sodium bicarbonate) helps to neutralize acid in the gut. As such, it is a common treatment for bloat, acidosis, and



other digestive upsets. It is the recommended treatment for floppy kid syndrome and “big and dumb” syndrome, both of which are characterized by a build-up of lactic acid in young

kids/lambs. Some producers offer baking soda free choice to their sheep/goats as a preventative for acidosis and/or bloat. In fact, free choice baking soda is a good idea for any sheep/goat that is fed a lot of grain. It can also be incorporated into the ration as a rumen buffer. Feed grade sodium bicarbonate is available (in bags) from most feed stores.

Beer

Beer (especially dark) has a long history of being used for livestock. Beer is given to animals that are off-feed. It is a source of fluids, energy, vitamins, and minerals. The yeast in beer may help to restart the rumen. Beer is sometimes given to a sow after she has finished giving birth to her piglets.

Supposably, the beer helps the sow relax and let her milk down.



Benadryl®

Benadryl® is an over-the-counter anti-histamine used to relieve symptoms of allergy, hay fever, and common colds. It is sometimes used to treat allergic reactions in sheep/goats.

Castor Oil

Castor oil is a vegetable oil pressed from castor beans. Besides being an energy source, castor oil can be used to treat various metabolic problems in sheep/goats, including acidosis, bloat, and constipation (in young lambs/kids). It is often included in homemade “colostrum” recipes for its nutritional value and laxative effect.

Cod liver oil

Cod liver oil is a dietary supplement derived from cod fish. It is a source of omega-3 fatty acids and vitamins A, D, and E. It has been used as a nutritional supplement for animals. It is sometimes added to homemade “colostrum” recipes.

Corn Oil

Corn oil is a dietary source of fat. It can be added to the ration to increase energy intake. It can also be given to animals that are off-feed or require an energy boost. If propylene glycol is not available, corn oil can be given to ewes/does in the initial stages of pregnancy toxemia (ketosis). Corn oil is commonly included in recipes for homemade “Nutri-Drench.”

Corn Syrup

Corn syrup is different from corn oil. It is a sweetener. It consists of half fructose and half dextrose (chemically identical to glucose). It can be given to ewes/does in the early stages of pregnancy toxemia (ketosis). Corn syrup is commonly included in recipes for homemade “Nutri-Drench.” Karo® syrup is a commercial product of corn syrup.

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Diatomaceous earth



Diatomaceous earth (DE; also known as Diatomite) is an off-white, talc-like powder that is the fossilized remains of tiny aquatic organisms. DE has many uses. It is an anti-

caking agent used in feed rations. It is used as an insecticide; DE products are registered for use against many pests. What DE is not is an effective dewormer. Despite testimonials, there is no scientific proof that DE has any effect on worm burdens in livestock. More studies are needed to determine if DE could have preventative properties instead of other health or production benefits to livestock.

Ensure® (or similar)

Ensure® provides nutrition in a tasty “shake.” It is often recommended for older people or those who need to gain weight. Ensure can provide a similar nutritional benefit for sheep/goats. Generic brands are less expensive than Ensure® and probably just as good.

Essential Oils

Essential oils are compounds extracted from plants. They have many potential benefits. Peppermint and tea tree oil have been used to



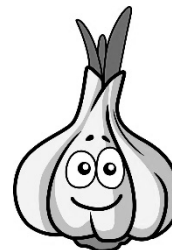
treat mastitis. Tea tree oil has been used to treat hoof disease. Oregano oil is being evaluated for its potential to prevent coccidiosis. Some essential oils are “hot” and need to be diluted with

carrier oils or water before they can be used. Be sure to do research before using essential oils. An increasing number of commercial products contain essential oils. Research is

currently underway to determine the benefits of different essential oils or mixtures on livestock health and productivity.

Garlic

Garlic products have the potential to improve ruminant growth and health, reduce methane emissions, and improve product quality. Garlic is a rich source of essential nutrients and phytochemicals. It is available in many forms. Studies are currently underway to evaluate the benefits of adding garlic to ruminant diets. Garlic is also touted as a “natural” dewormer. Unfortunately, there is little evidence that it kills worms. Perhaps it acts more of a preventative.



Gatorade®



Gatorade® is an electrolyte-restoring liquid (a “sports drink”). It can be used to rehydrate sheep/goats. It is commonly given to stressed animals. In fact, Penn State research showed that offering livestock Gatorade® helped to reduce weight loss during transportation. Gatorade®

is an option when commercial electrolyte solutions are not on-hand.

Honey

Honey is a sweet food substance made by bees. It is an energy source for sheep/goats. It can be given to animals that are off-feed or require an energy boost. Research is currently underway to evaluate the potential benefits of bee products on livestock nutrition and health.

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Jell-O

Jello (gelatin) is a sometimes treatment for diarrhea (scours). It can also make bitter tasting medicines more palatable. For example, Jello is often mixed with ammonium chloride (to treat urinary calculi) and DiMethox® (to treat coccidiosis).

Kaopectate®

Kaopectate® is an over-the-counter treatment for mild diarrhea. It is commonly used to treat non-infectious causes of diarrhea (scours) in sheep/goats. It can be purchased commercially (in larger quantities) as Kaolin Pectin.

Kefir



Kefir is a fermented milk drink, especially popular in the Middle East. Kefir contains more probiotics than yogurt. Kefir is commonly given to stressed animals to improve gut health. It may be most beneficial for livestock still on milk diets or transitioning off milk. Research is currently underway to determine the potential benefits of Kefir for livestock.

Milk of Magnesia

Milk of Magnesia is an over-the-counter antacid and laxative. It is used to treat various metabolic problems in sheep/goats, including bloat, acidosis, and constipation (in young lambs/kids).

Mineral Oil

Mineral oil is a must-have on any sheep/goat farm. It is a tasteless, odorless oil that can be

used to treat various metabolic problems, including bloat, acidosis, and constipation. It can also help to clear intestinal impaction or obstruction. Mineral oil is a laxative that lubricates the intestinal tract. When administering mineral oil, care must be taken to avoid aspiration into the lungs. Larger quantities of mineral oil should be administered using a stomach tube. Gallon jugs of mineral oil are commercially available from livestock supply companies.

Molasses

Molasses is a common feed ingredient (wet or dry). It is usually added to rations to increase palatability and remove dust.

Molasses is an energy source that can be given to animals that are off-feed or in need of an energy boost. It can be used to treat early-stage pregnancy toxemia (ketosis). Molasses can improve the palatability of other over-the-counter remedies. It is often included in recipes for homemade “Nutri-Drench.” Larger quantities of molasses can be purchased from farm or feed stores or stores that supply hunters.



Pedialyte®

Pedialyte® is an electrolyte drink for children. It can be used to rehydrate sheep/goats, especially young ones. Lambs/kids with scours often become dehydrated, regardless of the cause of the diarrhea, and need fluid replenishment. Pedialyte® is an option when commercial electrolyte solutions are not on-hand. Plus, it's available in smaller amounts, more suitable for sheep/goat.

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Pepto Bismol®

Pepto-Bismol® (bismuth subsalicylate) is commonly used to treat non-infectious causes of diarrhea (scours) in sheep/goats. Kaolin Pectin or Bismusal is sold commercially as an anti-diarrheal drug for livestock. It is similar to Pepto-Bismol®.

Triple Antibiotic

Triple antibiotic ointment is an over-the-counter antibiotic that can be used to heal and treat wounds and infections, including pink eye. It contains three antibiotics (neomycin + polymyxin + bacitracin); hence, its name. It comes in a tube and is relatively inexpensive.

Vegetable Oil

Besides being a dietary source of fat (energy), vegetable oils are used to treat metabolic problems in sheep/goats, including bloat and acidosis.

Vitamin C

While some producers use vitamin C (ascorbic acid) as an alternative treatment for the early stages of urinary calculi, there is no proof that it helps. The idea is that vitamin C may help to acidify the urine and dissolve the stones. Vitamin C has also been used in the prevention and treatment of mastitis. Animals with mastitis are often deficient in Vitamin C. Vitamin C is usually delivered via fresh fruit or vitamin C tablets or powder. It is also available as an injectable. Sheep/goats do not have a dietary requirement for vitamin C because they manufacture it as part of their normal metabolism.



WD-40®

There is some evidence that WD-40® (a penetrating" oil) may hasten the healing of lesions caused by soremouth (orf). The ether may break down the lipid in the virus. While soremouth is a self-limiting disease, it can cause production losses and prevent timely sale and exhibition of animals. Sheep/goat owners that have soremouth on their farms should consider timely vaccination.

Yeast

Yeast has been part of the human diet for thousands of years. In animal feed, yeast products have been used for over 40 years. Not all yeasts are the same. Yeast feed falls into two categories: live yeast probiotics (called direct-fed microbials) and prebiotics, which are non-viable yeasts or fractions of the yeast cell. Yeast optimizes digestive efficiency. Yeast products are used as a surrogate for livestock antibiotics. They are most beneficial for animals under stress or at risk of disease. Research continues to determine how to best use yeast products in livestock management.

Yogurt

Yogurt is a food produced by the bacterial fermentation of milk. It is a source of probiotics. Yogurt is commonly given to stressed animals. It helps to stimulate appetite and restore gut health. Many producers give it to animals with diarrhea (scours). Yogurt is oftentimes added to milk replacers to reduce the risk of abomasal bloat. When adding yogurt to milk, it is important not to feed the milk right away, as the bacteria



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need time to multiply. In addition to storebought yogurt, you can make your own yogurt from cow, goat, or sheep milk. Commercial probiotics are available from livestock supply companies and feed stores. There are also probiotic strains of silage inoculants. It is likely that future research will determine more precisely the role of probiotics (including yogurt and Kefir) in animal health and nutrition, as animal industries look for cost-effective “replacements” for antibiotics.

Questions regarding natural and home remedies and their use should be directed towards veterinarians and/or ruminant nutritionists.

Homemade Nutri-drench

1 cup corn oil
1 pint molasses
1 pint Karo® syrup

Homemade Electrolyte Solution

2 teaspoons baking soda
2 teaspoons salt
½ cup molasses or raw honey
4 quarts warm water

Homemade “colostrum” recipe*

3 cups milk
1 egg
1 tablespoon sugar, honey, or corn syrup
1 tablespoon cod liver oil (optional)

*Provides nutrients, but not antibodies.

Sources of the recipes are unknown. They are shared on the internet in multiple places.

